

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 178

Culture (OWC): [Tonga \(FQ12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1949, 1956-1957

Coverage Date: 1950-1957

Place Coverage: Eastern Southern Province, Zambia

Section Title(S)

Internal Organization of the Neighbourhood

I have described the clan joking system for the Plateau Tonga, and since it is very similar among the Valley Tonga I do not propose to go into any detail here.¹ Briefly, each clan is linked with a number of others in a permanent joking-relationship known as *bujwanyina*. Clan joking-partners perform various services for one another, particularly during funerals. A joking-partner, for instance, is chosen to begin the wailing after burial and also has the responsibility of announcing that the mourning should end. Joking-partners may seize one another's possessions, and can also beg from one another.

Plateau joking-partners have a responsibility for the burial of those who die certain kinds of deaths, as from leprosy or suicide; they also take part in rituals which disperse mystical dangers arising from incest, attempted suicide and other instances of *malweza*, i.e. unnatural events or actions and the evil which may follow from them. Valley joking-partners have fewer functions, though work in 1962-3 discovered that they act in cases of suicide or would-be suicide. I suspect that this may be due to the fact that in the Valley the neighbourhood and the unilineal descent group are more tightly organized and have greater control over their members; there is less need therefore to depend upon the institutionalized outsider to shame and thus control an offender. Valley people deny that they have any rituals to purge the culprit of the evil of incest or suicide. The function of giving publicity to misdeeds, given to clan joking-partners on the Plateau, is taken over by the song-makers. Scandal is publicized in songs used either for the young people's dance or by the Drum team of the neighbourhood. When a man eloped with his sister's co-wife, a deed akin to incest, the indignant husband announced that he would have a song-maker immortalize the deed in song that would make his brother-in-law's name notorious wherever the Drum performed. When a CHEZIA girl

128
[Organization And Analysis Of Results](#)

602
[Kin Relationships](#)

614
[Clans](#)

171
[Comparative Evidence](#)

533
[Music](#)

602
[Kin Relationships](#)

613
[Lineages](#)

621
[Community Structure](#)

626
[Social Control](#)

762

eloped with a man from another area who turned out to belong to her clan, the Drum proclaimed her shame in a song with the refrain, 'Her buttocks are rotten. Maensa sleeps with her brother.' The young people of  179 Sinafwala danced gaily to a song that described the thievish nature of the people of Madonda Village after the latter had stolen hippo meat apportioned to Sinafwala. Both Sinafwala and Madonda belong to the CHEZIA Drum, so the song of the hippo never became a Drum song. Madonda villagers refused to dance to the outrageous comment upon their misdeeds.

[Suicide](#)

835

[Kinship Regulation Of Sex](#)

¹ See Colson, 1953 *b*.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)